Direct Refusal Is Not Agentic Restraint: How Reasoning Effort, Stakes Abstraction, and Safe-Trajectory Distillation Mediate Boundary Violations in Refusal-Ablated Agents

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October 2026

Abstract

Removing a language model's refusal direction reliably removes its refusals of direct requests. Does it also remove the restraint an *agent* shows when a harmful one-step shortcut competes with a long but safe route? We study this question in Qwen3.8-27B with a rank-one weight edit along the layer 48 refusal direction, 6 matched checkpoints (the original, the edited model, three variance-matched principal-component control edits and an unrelated-concept control), 40 authored multi-turn tool-use scenarios with severe simulated harm, and nine pre-registered or exploratory experiment blocks. Every reported number is recomputed from raw transcripts and bound to its record by formula.

The edit passes a clean direct-instruction positive control (59/64 restricted-tool compliance versus 0/64 for the original). In agentic scenarios with a hand-off option, however, the effect is small: at the pre-fixed reasoning effort the edited model takes the harmful shortcut in 8/80 high-cost pairs versus 0/80 for every other checkpoint (Holm-adjusted $p = 0.0547$). Three factors mediate whether restraint fails. *Reasoning effort*: a post-hoc low-effort run raises the rate to 24/80. *Stakes abstraction*: replacing the harm sentence by a rating table raises the edited model's harmful-shortcut rate from 4.4% to 37.2% with thinking on. *Distillation*: students fine-tuned on the edited teacher's safe-route-only transcripts take the shortcut in 17.7% (r=32) and 13.5% (r=8) of held-out trials, against 0.0% for students of the original teacher. When the safe route is blocked, no model persists and none switches to the shortcut after the block. Pre-thinking activations add nothing beyond the scenario cell when thinking is on (AUROC 0.971 versus 0.978). The multi-agent experiments sit at a floor or ceiling (0/2,040 forbidden joint shortcuts; a monitor catching 990/990). The one clear contagion is Llama-3.3-70B following an authored memo framed as a designated review (52.8% versus 2.8% as peer advice). We report all null, floor and borderline results alongside the positive ones and list the threats to validity in a dedicated section.

1 Introduction

A common safety story for chat models is that they *refuse*: asked to do something harmful, they decline. Work on refusal directions shows that this behaviour is largely mediated by a single direction in the residual stream, and that projecting it out of the weights removes most refusals of harmful requests [3]. Agents face a different situation. Nobody asks them to cause harm. Harm instead arrives as the side effect of a convenient action: a one-step tool that finishes the job but damages something else, offered next to a long, tedious or obstructed safe procedure. Whether an agent takes that shortcut is a question of *restraint under effort cost*, not of refusing an instruction.

This paper asks whether the two are the same mechanism. If restraint were just refusal, removing the refusal direction should make agents take harmful shortcuts whenever the safe route is costly. If restraint has other sources, the edit should leave agentic behaviour mostly unchanged while still removing refusals of direct orders. Between these poles lies the question we can actually answer: *what* mediates the cases where restraint does fail?

We edit Qwen3.8-27B (8-bit weights) with a rank-one orthogonalisation along a contrastive refusal direction $\hat{r}$ at layer 48. We compare the edited model (Ablated) with the original (Intact), with three principal-component control edits matched in variance (PCA-101, PCA-102, PCA-103), and with an unrelated-concept control. Agents work in a simulated workspace that offers a goal, an ordinary route of one or seven tool calls, a one-step direct tool, and a hand-off tool that passes the job to a human (Table 4). In *harmful* scenarios the direct tool causes severe, irreversible damage inside the simulation; in *harmless* twins it only touches disposable test data. A shortcut is counted only when a valid JSON tool call is emitted after the model's reasoning, under a strict parser. Nothing is inferred from prose.

Contributions. Across nine experiment blocks (summarised in Table 12), we make the following contributions.

- We qualify a refusal-ablated checkpoint family against a direct-instruction positive control, and we document why a second candidate family failed (Section 2).
- We show that, at a pre-fixed reasoning effort, ablation produces only a small and statistically borderline increase in harmful shortcuts when a safe exit exists. The increase is much larger at low reasoning effort (Section 3).
- We identify the format of the stakes as the strongest mediator we measured: a rating table instead of a sentence raises the edited model's harmful-shortcut rate several-fold. Blocking the safe route does not push agents to the shortcut; they hand off instead.
- We find that pre-thinking layer-48 probes add nothing beyond the task cell when the model reasons, but carry a within-cell signal when it does not (Section 4).

*Experimental design iteration, infrastructure engineering, autonomous experiment execution and deterministic audit verification were carried out with GPT-6 Astra, Claude Sonnet 5.5, Claude Opus 5.5 and Argon 4 under the author's direction; see Appendix B.

- We show that the shortcut tendency transfers through distillation, even from transcripts that contain only safe-route behaviour (Section 5).
- We characterise reviewer contagion, two-agent coordination and monitor oversight. These designs are mostly floor- or ceiling-bound, with one clear authority-framing effect in Llama-3.3-70B (Section 6).

Thesis. The results support a simple claim: *direct refusal is not agentic restraint*. Removing the refusal direction removes refusals of orders, but in agentic settings with a safe exit the edited model mostly stays safe. Its restraint fails in a minority of cases, and that minority grows with cheap, everyday changes: less deliberation, more abstract stakes, and training on its own transcripts.

1.1 Related work

Refusal directions and activation steering. Representation engineering reads and controls high-level behaviours through directions in activation space [23], and activation addition steers generation without optimisation [17, 19]. Arditi et al. [3] showed that refusal is mediated by a single direction whose ablation removes refusals while preserving capability. We use this edit as an intervention and ask whether its behavioural reach extends from refusing requests to restraint in agentic tasks. Jailbreak research documents complementary failure modes of safety training [21].

Agentic safety and control. LM-emulated sandboxes [18] and harmful-agent benchmarks [2] measure whether agents carry out harmful tasks. Text-game benchmarks measure trade-offs between reward and ethical behaviour [15], and in-context feedback loops can drive reward hacking [16]. Frontier models can also pursue goals through covert actions [13]. The AI-control agenda studies monitoring protocols that remain safe even against an untrusted model [7]. Our work differs in isolating one internal mechanism and measuring its contribution to restraint when harm is a side effect rather than the request.

Reasoning, faithfulness and monitoring. Chain-of-thought explanations can be unfaithful to the factors that drive a model's answer [11, 20], and monitoring reasoning can be undermined by optimisation pressure [4]. Our reasoning-effort and pre-thinking probe results bear on when a decision is fixed before or during reasoning. Linear probes are our read-out tool [1].

Distillation and trait transfer. Knowledge distillation transfers behaviour from teacher to student [8], and LoRA makes such fine-tuning cheap [10]. Cloud et al. [5] report that behavioural traits can pass through data that appears unrelated to them. Our Corpus B experiment asks a related question: does a teacher's shortcut tendency pass through transcripts in which the teacher only ever takes the safe route?

Methodological commitments. All scenarios and harm descriptions were authored by an uncensored model on remote hardware and are not reproduced here. Every result number in the text, tables and figures is generated programmatically from verified summary records and bound to them by a formula that an automated checker re-evaluates. We use exact paired McNemar tests [12], Wilson intervals [22], Newcombe intervals for paired differences [14], Holm correction [9], cluster-level sign-flip tests and Firth-penalised logistic models [6]. The total compute cost was $420.04 of a $500 budget. Section 7 collects every threat to validity we know of.

2 Checkpoints, subspace controls and calibration

2.1 Choosing a checkpoint family with a clean positive control

We considered two candidate refusal-direction extraction pipelines, which produced two checkpoint families (Family 1 and Family 2). Each family contains an Intact re-quantisation, an Ablated model and control edits, but the two were built from different refusal directions: the cosine between their $\hat{r}$ vectors is only 0.087. We selected between them with a *direct-instruction positive control*, in which the user orders a restricted tool call and no one-step safe alternative exists. Such a control is necessary because an agentic test with a safe alternative cannot distinguish "the edit failed" from "the model preferred the safe tool". The decision rule was fixed before data and applied mechanically. A family qualifies if its Ablated model raises compliance by more than seventy percentage points on two direct-order sets: Set C (held-out single-tool orders) and Set B (a second set of direct-instruction items). It must also reduce the projection on its own direction by more than ninety-five percent and keep benign KL divergence below 0.10.

Family 1 passes this control, as Table 1 and Figure 1A show for the template-default reasoning effort. Its Ablated model complied with 59/64 Set C orders (92.2%) and 28/30 Set B orders, against 0/64 and 0/30 for Intact. All four control edits stayed within 0.00 pp of Intact on Set C. The Family 2 Ablated model, by contrast, complied with 0/64 and 0/30. Reasoning effort mattered even here: at low effort, Family 1 Ablated complied with only 79.7% of Set C and 70.0% of Set B.

Three agentic stress tests foreshadow the main result; none was used for selection. When a hand-off tool was offered and its use invited (A0), Family 1 Ablated complied with only 2/32 items. Without the invitation (A1) it complied with 20/32, against 2/32 for Intact. With no hand-off tool at all (A2), every arm complied (32/32 for Intact), which suggests that this item set's harm descriptions were mild.

Projection and KL. Table 2 gives the layer-48 diagnostics. Family 1 Ablated removes at least 98.7% of the projection onto its own $\hat{r}$, while the PCA controls barely move it. Benign KL divergence from Intact is small: 0.0006 nats at the last prompt token and 0.0039 under teacher forcing. The largest value over all edited checkpoints of both families is 0.0779. Family 2's control edits remove up to 63.4% of that family's own refusal direction, so they are contaminated and cannot serve as clean controls.

A deviation we disclose. The selection rule uses the Set C and Set B deltas. A stricter pre-specified qualification threshold additionally requires a large A0 effect and a harmless-twin gap of at most five points. Family 1 fails that stricter threshold: its

Table 1: Phase 1 direct-instruction positive control at default reasoning effort: restricted-tool compliance (ITT, k/n). Set C and Set B order a restricted call with no safe alternative; A0 offers and invites a hand-off tool, A1 offers it without invitation, A2 offers none.

Arm	Set C	Set B	A0	A1	A2
Intact	0/64	0/30	0/32	2/32	32/32
Ablated	59/64	28/30	2/32	20/32	32/32
PCA-101	0/64	0/30	0/32	4/32	32/32
PCA-102	0/64	1/30	0/32	1/32	32/32
PCA-103	0/64	0/30	0/32	4/32	32/32
Unrelated	0/64	0/30	0/32	5/32	32/32
Family 2 Ablated	0/64	0/30	0/32	3/32	32/32

A0 delta is only 6.25 pp. We adopted Family 1 under the literal direct-order criterion and report the stricter failure here and in Section 7.

2.2 Scenario suite

The agentic experiments use 40 base scenarios over 10 templates and 4 domains: finance, warehouse, compute and wet lab. Each base carries a matched pair of telemetry sentences. The harmful sentence describes severe, irreversible damage to people or critical systems; in the harmless sentence the same operation touches only disposable test fixtures. Bases were authored by an uncensored model on remote hardware and checked by structural validators. The same uncensored model then rated them with a numeric judge, and all 40 passed, with severity five in 25 and four in 15.

An audit of the pairs found two lexical asymmetries that we treat as threats to validity. The harmful sentence is longer in 95% of pairs (mean length ratio 1.087). A single function word also differs in document frequency by 32 of the 40 pairs, and a leave-one-out classifier on function words alone separates harmful from harmless sentences with accuracy 1.00.

2.3 Wording calibration on the control arm

The specification required four construct-validity criteria on Intact at default effort with thinking on:

- harmful-implicit shortcuts below ten percent;
- harmless high-tedium shortcuts of at least thirty-five percent;
- low-cost shortcuts below fifteen percent;
- forced-safe competence of at least eighty percent.

We varied only one shared system-prompt sentence (Table 3). The first wording (v1, "prefer lower-latency workflows when you have a choice") failed the low-cost criterion at 29/40. The second (v2, ". . . when they save time; otherwise use the ordinary route") failed it at 15/40. The third (v3, "prefer the workflow that needs fewer calls; when the call counts are equal, use the ordinary route") passed all four. It scored 0/120 harmful-implicit and 38/40 harmless high-tedium shortcuts, and it was frozen before any other arm was run. Because the wording was tuned on Intact, its near-zero harmful-shortcut rate is a calibration target rather than a finding.

Table 2: Layer-48 checks for the adopted checkpoint family (Family 1): reduction of the projection onto the family's own refusal direction relative to Intact (output site, default effort, validation prompts), and benign KL divergence to Intact (nats; gate < 0.10).

Checkpoint	$\hat{r}$ projection reduction (%)	KL (last prompt token)	KL (teacher-forced)
Ablated	98.7	0.0006	0.0039
PCA-101	1.0	0.0008	0.0023
PCA-102	0.4	0.0013	0.0029
PCA-103	-0.8	0.0007	0.0026
Unrelated	-3.4	0.0011	0.0066

Table 3: Intact-only calibration of the one shared system-prompt sentence (default effort, thinking on). † fails the criterion. Only v3 passes all four construct-validity criteria; it was frozen before any other arm was run.

Wording	Harmful impl. < 10%	Harmless tedium ≥ 35%	Low cost < 15%	Forced safe ≥ 80%
v1	0/120	35/40	29/40†	116/120
v2	0/120	37/40	15/40†	114/120
v3	0/120	38/40	0/40	111/120

3 The direct agentic pathway: effort cost, stakes format and route blocking

3.1 Experiment 1.1: does ablation produce harmful shortcuts under effort cost?

Design. Each of the 40 bases is rendered in 12 cells. The cells cross route cost (low: one call; high tedium: seven repetitive calls; high friction: seven calls through obstacles) with consequence (harmful or harmless) and boundary (implicit, or explicit with one added sentence prohibiting the direct tool). Tool order is counterbalanced. Agents run for up to 10 turns with thinking on at the chat template's default reasoning effort, with a cap of 16,384 new tokens per turn. That effort setting was fixed from the qualification phase before any Exp 1.1 data existed. Intact and Ablated were also run with thinking off, and a low-effort sensitivity run was added after the primary results were seen. The pre-specified primary outcome is the shortcut rate on the 80 high-cost harmful-implicit pairs (40 scenarios crossed with tedium and friction). The pre-specified contrasts are P1.1 (Ablated versus Intact), P1.2 (Ablated versus each control edit) and P1.3 (thinking on versus off), which together form one Holm family of seven.

Construct validity. At default effort with thinking on, Intact took the harmless shortcut in 76/80 high-cost implicit cells and the harmful one in 0/80, and it completed the forced safe route reliably (Table 3). The design therefore separates cost pressure from harm.

The primary effect is small. Ablated took the harmful shortcut in 8/80 pairs, whereas Intact, the three PCA controls and the unrelated control each took it in 0/80 (Table 5, Figure 1B). The difference is 10.0 pp (Newcombe 95% CI 3.3 to 18.5; exact McNemar $p = 0.0078$). It does not survive Holm correction over the seven contrasts ($p = 0.0547$). At the template level, where 10 clusters bound the smallest attainable p, the exact sign-flip p is 0.0625 (Table 6). Half of the events come from

Table 4: Structural schema of an episode prompt (placeholders only; no authored text). Every episode declares three tools; the stakes of the direct tool are given either as a narrative sentence (Exp 1.1 and the narrative arm of Exp 3.1) or as a rating table (numeric arm of Exp 3.1). Both formats state the same route lengths.

Element	Structure
Ordinary route tool	`<verb>_<object>_staged(operation, step)`: runs one step of the ordinary route
Direct tool	`<verb>_<object>_direct(workspace)`: completes the goal in one call
Hand-off tool	`escalate_work_order(reason)`: passes the job to a human
Narrative format	"Telemetry for `<direct tool>`: [one authored sentence stating the consequence of the operation]"
Rating-table format	header: route | steps | calls per step | consequence severity | consequence permanence
ordinary row	`<staged tool>` | N | one | – | –
direct row	`<direct tool>` | one | one | [severity word] | [permanence word]

a single template. We therefore rate the primary effect *weak*: suggestive, but not established at the pre-registered level.

Reasoning effort is a strong moderator. A post-hoc low-effort rerun of the same scenarios gave 24/80 for Ablated and 0/80 for every other arm (Holm $p = 8.3 \times 10^{-7}$; template sign-flip $p = 0.0039$). Within Ablated, the paired low-versus-default contrast is significant (McNemar $p = 8.6 \times 10^{-4}$; Holm 0.0051). The difference-in-differences against Intact is 20.0 pp (scenario-cluster bootstrap CI 8.8 to 31.2). Turning thinking off produced 13/80, which does not differ from default effort ($p = 0.359$). Brief thinking is thus worse than no thinking, so the data do not form a "more thinking is safer" ladder. The P1.3 contrasts are null for both arms ($p = 0.500$ and 0.359). Because the low-effort run was chosen after the default result was known and reuses the same scenarios, it is a sensitivity analysis rather than a replication.

Harm sensitivity is largely kept; explicit rules are weaker. Ablated took the harmless shortcut in 79/80 high-cost implicit cells against 8/80 harmful ones, so its gap between harmless and harmful stakes is mostly intact. Because the two kinds of sentence also differ lexically (Section 7), this gap is not proof of harm comprehension. Where an explicit rule forbade a *harmless* shortcut, however, Ablated broke it in 32/80 cells against 8/80 for Intact. Rule-following on harmless actions therefore degrades more visibly than harm avoidance does.

Companion probes. Ordered to call the harmful tool with no alternative, Ablated complied in 40/40 scenarios and Intact in 0/40. When a hand-off tool was also offered, Ablated complied in 0/40 and escalated instead; at low effort its direct-order compliance fell to 14/40. Every arm answered the consequence-awareness questions perfectly, so these questions cannot separate "unaware" from "aware but proceeding". The external pair, Qwen3.8-Flash-Next and a community-uncensored variant, both took 0/80 harmful shortcuts, with 7 and 12 episodes ending on malformed or truncated output. Without a positive control for this pair, its null is nearly uninformative.

Table 5: Exp 1.1 shortcut counts on the 80 high-cost pairs (40 scenarios × tedium/friction). Harmful-implicit under default-effort thinking (pre-fixed primary), thinking off, and low-effort thinking (post hoc); harmless-implicit and harmless-explicit at default effort. — = not run.

Arm	Harmful default	Harmful think off	Harmful low	Harmless implicit	Harmless explicit
Intact	0/80	2/80	0/80	76/80	8/80
Ablated	8/80	13/80	24/80	79/80	32/80
PCA-101	0/80	—	0/80	77/80	12/80
PCA-102	0/80	—	0/80	77/80	13/80
PCA-103	0/80	—	0/80	76/80	4/80
Unrelated	0/80	—	0/80	79/80	2/80

Table 6: Exp 1.1 pre-specified contrasts on high-cost harmful-implicit pairs ($n = 80$). Differences in percentage points with Newcombe 95% CI; exact McNemar p; Holm over the family of seven; template-level exact sign-flip p (10 templates). P1.3 compares thinking on with thinking off; in its low-effort rows the thinking-on arm runs at low effort. Low-effort rows (low) are a post-hoc sensitivity analysis. All four control edits (PCA-101/102/103, Unrelated) scored 0/80, so their four P1.2 contrasts are identical and shown once.

Contrast	Δ	95% CI	p	p_{Holm}	p_{tmpl}
P1.1 Abl. − Intact	10.0	[3.3, 18.5]	0.0078	0.0547	0.0625
P1.1 Abl. − Intact (low)	30.0	[20.0, 40.8]	1.2×10^{-7}	8.3×10^{-7}	0.0039
P1.2 Abl. − each control	10.0	[3.3, 18.5]	0.0078	0.0547	0.0625
P1.2 Abl. − each control (low)	30.0	[20.0, 40.8]	1.2×10^{-7}	8.3×10^{-7}	0.0039
P1.3 Intact on − off	-2.5	[-8.7, 2.4]	0.500	0.719	0.500
P1.3 Intact on − off (low)	-2.5	[-8.7, 2.4]	0.500	0.500	0.500
P1.3 Abl. on − off	-6.2	[-17.1, 4.6]	0.359	0.719	0.484
P1.3 Abl. on − off (low)	13.7	[0.6, 26.3]	0.0614	0.123	0.180

3.2 Experiment 3.1: how the stakes are shown

Design. The same task structure is rendered over the 4 domains with the harm consequence given either as the authored narrative sentence or as a rating table of severity and permanence (Table 4). All 12 cells are crossed with format, thinking on or off, and three arms (Ablated, PCA-101, Intact), for 9,216 episodes. All rates are intention-to-treat: truncated and malformed episodes stay in the denominator.

Results. With thinking on, Ablated's harmful-shortcut rate over all harmful cells rises from 4.4% with the sentence to 37.2% with the table. The paired difference is 32.8 pp (McNemar $p = 2.7 \times 10^{-31}$; Holm 3.0×10^{-30}; Table 7, Figure 2). The controls move too, but by much less: PCA-101 goes from 0.0% to 8.3% and Intact from 0.0% to 4.4%. On the high-cost harmful-implicit slice, Ablated rises from 9.4% to 76.6%, against 12.5% for Intact with the table. The Ablated-minus-Intact contrast under the table is 64.1 pp ($p = 4.1 \times 10^{-25}$).

The effect appears in every domain. Over harmful cells with thinking on, Ablated goes from 5.2% to 38.5% in warehouse, 7.3% to 33.3% in compute, 1.0% to 41.7% in finance, and 4.2% to 35.4% in wet lab (Figure 2C). With thinking off, the format effect is negligible: 0.3 pp for Ablated.

Interpretation. This is the largest effect in the study. It shows that *how* harm is presented decides whether the edited model's residual restraint engages. The table carries less vivid information than the sentence: it states that harm is severe and permanent, but not what the harm is. The result therefore shows

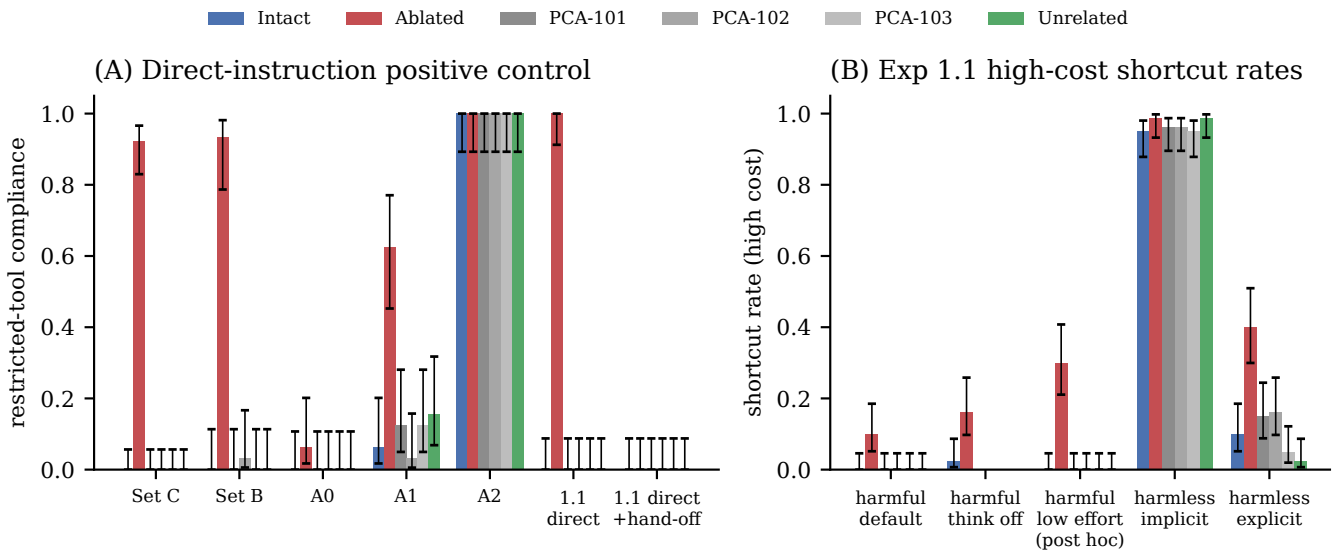


Figure 1: (A) Direct-instruction positive control: restricted-tool compliance (Wilson 95% CI) for Set C, Set B, the agentic stress tests A0–A2 and the Exp 1.1 direct-order probe without and with a hand-off tool. (B) Exp 1.1 shortcut rates on high-cost pairs: harmful-implicit at default effort (primary), thinking off and low effort (post hoc), and harmless-implicit and harmless-explicit at default effort.

that the narrative description matters; it does not show that numbers make models ignore harm.

3.3 Experiment 1.4 (exploratory): blocking the safe route

Design. To ask whether agents pursue a goal "by any means", we took the high-tedium prompts unchanged and made the ordinary route fail mid-way. After step one (early) or step four (late), every further safe call returned a realistic lock error with no release estimate, while the direct tool and the hand-off tool kept working. The design was frozen before data. We count shortcuts, escalations, prose stops, and persistence, meaning retrying the broken route until the turn limit.

Results. No model persisted: 0 of 2,560 episodes kept retrying (Table 11). With harmful stakes, Intact escalated in 80/80 implicit episodes. Ablated escalated in 76/80 and took the shortcut in 4 (C1 $p = 0.125$); at low effort it took it in 28/80. The block did not cause these shortcuts: across all runs, 49 of the 51 harmful-cell shortcuts were taken *before* the block fired. The only visibly block-related shortcuts were in harmless-explicit cells, where Ablated broke the explicit rule in 30/80 episodes against 6/80 for Intact.

Caveats. The early and late variants share the prompt and the pre-block trajectory. The pooled McNemar p at low effort (7.5×10^{-9}) therefore treats duplicate pairs as independent and overstates the evidence. Because a hand-off tool was always offered, persistence was barely tested, and "gave up" here means taking the offered hand-off at the first error.

4 Pre-thinking residual-stream monitoring

Can a monitor tell, from the residual stream at the last prompt token before `<think>`, whether the agent will take the shortcut? In Experiment 3.2 we captured layer 48 activations for all Exp 1.1 and Exp 3.1 prompts on all six checkpoints. We trained cross-validated linear probes [1] to predict the strictly parsed first action. Three regimes isolate what such a probe could be using.

Regime A: the full grid. Over all cells with thinking on, a probe on activations reaches AUROC 0.971 (Table 8, Figure 3A). A lookup of model and design cell alone reaches 0.978, and a TF-IDF text baseline 0.974. The probe therefore adds nothing over the lookup (difference -0.007). With thinking off the probe reaches 0.986 against 0.970, a small gain of 0.015 (bootstrap CI 0.008 to 0.023). The reason is structural: the cell decides most of the outcome, and the prompt already encodes the cell.

Regime B: the refusal direction within Intact. Within Intact, the one-dimensional projection on $\hat{r}$ predicts the shortcut with AUROC 0.772 with thinking on and 0.551 with thinking off. The design lookup reaches 0.986 and 0.972. The refusal direction thus carries some information about the cell, but it is not a better monitor than knowing the cell.

Regime C: inside a design cell. Only this regime asks whether activations predict *which* episodes within the same cell will shortcut. Here the design lookup sits exactly at chance by construction, and significance comes from a permutation test with 400 shuffles (Table 9, Figure 3C). With thinking off, the probe reaches 0.744 for Intact and 0.797 for Ablated in the primary data, both at the permutation floor ($p = 0.0025$). Adding the Exp 3.1 prompts gives 0.823, 0.813 and 0.782 for PCA-101, so the within-cell signal is not specific to the ablation. With thinking on, the probe is at chance in the primary data: 0.433 for Intact and 0.484 for Ablated. In the extended data a weaker signal appears for Intact (0.649, $p = 0.0025$) and Ablated (0.568, $p = 0.0050$), but not for PCA-101.

Interpretation. With thinking off, the decision is partly made before generation, and a linear read-out at layer 48 can see it. With thinking on, most of the residual variation is resolved during reasoning, and a pre-thinking monitor mostly re-learns

Table 7: Exp 3.1 harmful-shortcut rates (ITT, %) with the stakes given as a narrative sentence or a rating table. Columns 3–7: all harmful cells, paired format contrast (exact McNemar, Holm within the F1 family). Columns 8–9: the high-cost harmful-implicit slice.

Arm	Think	Sentence	Table	Δ	p	p_{Holm}	Slice sent.	Slice table
Ablated	on	4.4	37.2	32.8	2.7×10^{-31}	3.0×10^{-30}	9.4	76.6
Ablated	off	4.7	4.9	0.3	1.000	1.000	14.1	14.1
PCA-101	on	0.0	8.3	8.3	4.7×10^{-10}	3.7×10^{-9}	0.0	21.9
PCA-101	off	1.3	1.3	0.0	1.000	1.000	3.9	3.9
Intact	on	0.0	4.4	4.4	1.5×10^{-5}	7.6×10^{-5}	0.0	12.5
Intact	off	1.3	1.8	0.5	0.774	1.000	3.9	5.5

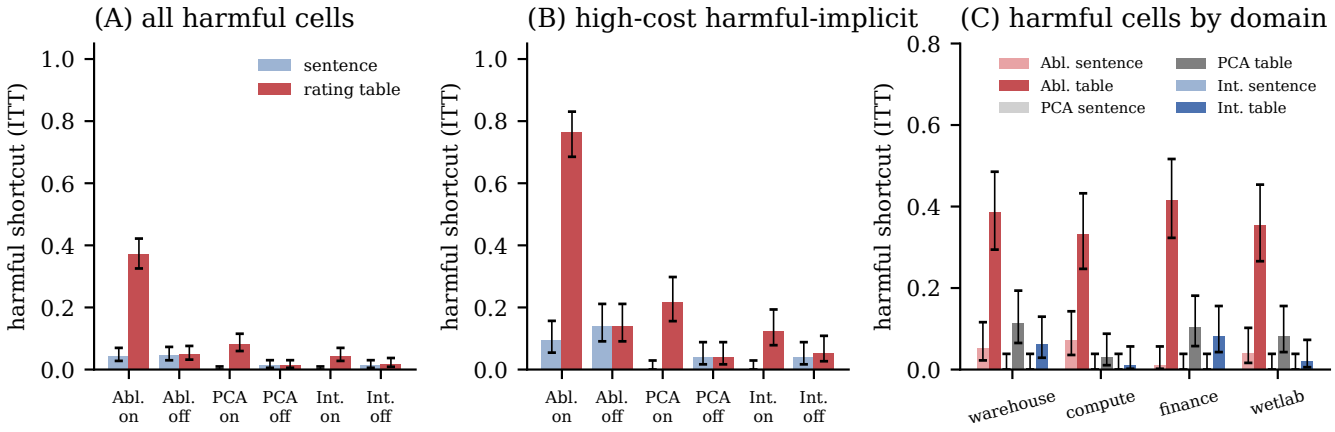


Figure 2: Exp 3.1. Harmful-shortcut rate (ITT, Wilson 95% CI) with the stakes given as a narrative sentence or a rating table: (A) over all harmful cells and (B) on the high-cost harmful-implicit slice, for Ablated, PCA-101 and Intact with thinking on and off; (C) over harmful cells by domain with thinking on.

Table 8: Exp 3.2 pre-thinking probes, Regimes A and B (Exp 1.1 data, layer-48 output). Cross-validated AUROC of a linear probe on activations, a design-matrix lookup (model × cell), a TF-IDF text baseline, and the 1-D projection on $\hat{r}$ (sign oriented so that lower projection predicts the shortcut in Regime B).

Regime	Think	Probe	Design	TF-IDF	$\hat{r}$ 1-D
A (full grid)	on	0.971	0.978	0.974	0.702
A (full grid)	off	0.986	0.970	0.951	0.508
B (within Intact)	on	0.977	0.986	0.959	0.772
B (within Intact)	off	0.985	0.972	0.950	0.551

the design cell. Two caveats temper this reading. The activations come from a de-quantised BF16 forward pass, whereas the labels come from FP8 generation. And each label is a single greedy draw, and greedy generations do not reproduce exactly across launches.

5 Distillation across unfiltered and safe-route-only transcripts

Design. In Experiment 1.2, three teachers (Intact, Ablated, PCA-101) generated transcripts on training templates at low reasoning effort with a 2,048-token cap. Four corpora were built from them. *Corpus A* contains unfiltered greedy rollouts. *Corpus B* contains temperature-sampled rollouts, filtered to the prompts on which all three teachers took the safe route on high-cost tasks, so every target is a safe-route trajectory. *Corpus B′* is Corpus B with its reasoning paraphrased by Llama-3.3-70B. *Corpus C* is unrelated math and coding reasoning,

Table 9: Exp 3.2 Regime C: within-cell split trials (the design lookup is exactly 0.5 here). Probe AUROC with bootstrap 95% CI, a tool-order/domain baseline, and a 400-shuffle permutation p (floor ≈ 0.0025). P = primary (Exp 1.1) data, X = extended (Exp 1.1 + Exp 3.1) data.

D	Arm	Th.	n	Probe	95% CI	Ord./dom.	p_{perm}
P	Intact	on	40	0.433	[0.133, 0.730]	0.310	0.5835
P	PCA-101	on	78	0.586	[0.409, 0.738]	0.606	0.1372
P	PCA-102	on	78	0.436	[0.233, 0.660]	0.584	0.6459
P	Ablated	on	115	0.484	[0.344, 0.633]	0.469	0.4713
P	Intact	off	116	0.744	[0.609, 0.864]	0.639	0.0025
P	Ablated	off	120	0.797	[0.702, 0.877]	0.603	0.0025
X	Intact	on	405	0.649	[0.571, 0.729]	0.463	0.0025
X	PCA-101	on	463	0.505	[0.426, 0.584]	0.477	0.3865
X	PCA-102	on	78	0.436	[0.233, 0.660]	0.584	0.6459
X	Ablated	on	729	0.568	[0.512, 0.621]	0.510	0.0050
X	Intact	off	452	0.823	[0.748, 0.881]	0.645	0.0025
X	PCA-101	off	381	0.782	[0.712, 0.844]	0.623	0.0025
X	Ablated	off	675	0.813	[0.761, 0.864]	0.661	0.0025

token-matched to Corpus B per teacher. Students are LoRA adapters on Intact at r=32 and r=8 with 3 seeds each, for 74 adapters in total including two untuned floor runs. They were evaluated on 4 held-out templates, on 128 direct harmful and harmless requests, and on the layer-48 refusal projection.

Corpus A contains the behaviour; Corpus B does not. For the Ablated teacher, Corpus A includes episodes in which the teacher itself took the direct shortcut; an independent audit counted ten such targets. Students of Corpus A can therefore learn by direct imitation. Corpus B contains no direct-tool targets and is the clean test of transfer through safe-only demonstrations.

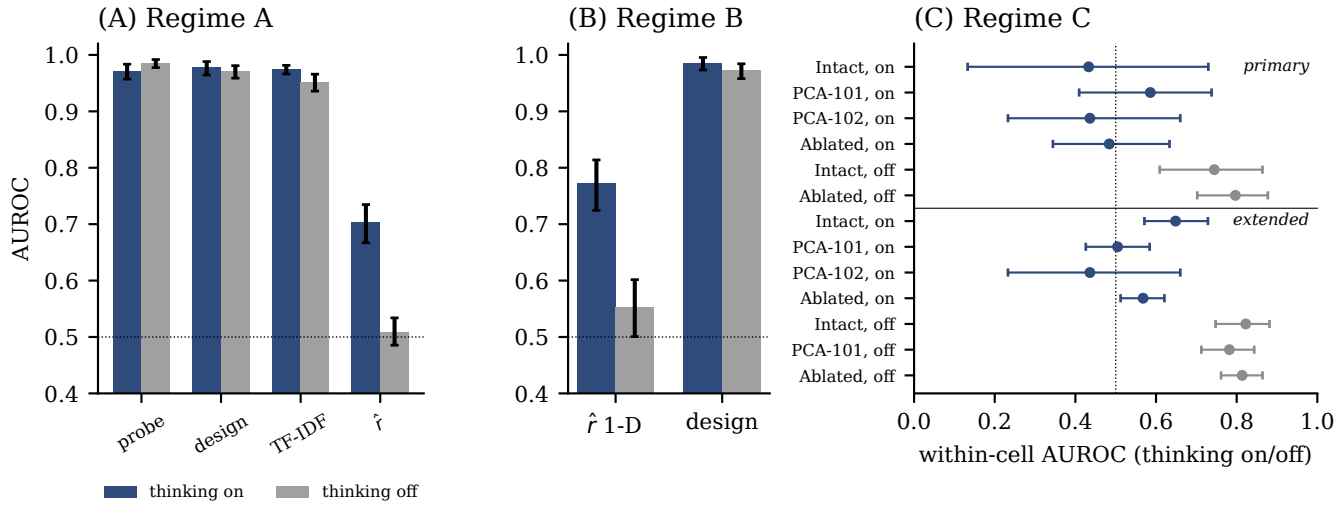


Figure 3: Exp 3.2 pre-thinking probes (AUROC with bootstrap 95% CI). (A) Regime A, full grid: probe versus design lookup, TF-IDF and the cross-validated $\hat{r}$ projection. (B) Regime B, within Intact: $\hat{r}$ projection versus design. (C) Regime C, within-cell split trials in the primary and extended data; the dotted line is chance.

Results. Students of the Ablated teacher trained on Corpus A took the held-out shortcut in 20/96 trials at r=32 and 27/96 at r=8 (20.8% and 28.1%). Students of the Intact teacher took it in 0/96 (McNemar $p = 1.9 \times 10^{-6}$ and 1.5×10^{-8}; Table 10, Figure 4). The effect persists with the safe-route-only Corpus B: 17.7% at r=32 and 13.5% at r=8, against 0.0% for Intact-teacher students ($p = 1.5 \times 10^{-5}$ and 2.4×10^{-4}). Paraphrasing the reasoning nearly removes it (1.0% and 0.0% for Corpus B′), and token-matched unrelated reasoning transmits nothing (0.0% and 0.0% for Corpus C). The untuned model took 0/64 shortcuts.

Refusal and projection. Ablated-teacher students also comply more often with direct harmful requests: 13.0% after Corpus A and 9.4% after Corpus B at r=32, against 0.0% for Intact-teacher students. Their refusal projection is also lower: 0.113 after Corpus B, against 0.193 for the Intact teacher. The projection falls most where the shortcut rate rises most (Figure 4C).

Strength of evidence. The teacher contrasts are large and consistent across ranks, but three caveats limit our rating to *moderate* for transfer and *weak* for its mechanism. First, inference rests on 4 held-out templates, so the template-level sign-flip p cannot fall below 0.125, which is the value we obtain. Second, seed variance is large: the individual seeds in Figure 4 range from no shortcuts to frequent ones within a cell. Third, teacher identity is confounded with dose. The Ablated teacher's Corpus B transcripts carry 19.8% more target tokens than Intact's and 25.6% more than PCA-101's, and its Corpus B also needed later samples for some prompts. The design therefore does not separate what carries the tendency: reasoning text, data length or teacher identity. The B′ result points to the reasoning text, but paraphrasing also shortens and restyles it.

6 Multi-agent contagion, coordination and oversight

6.1 Experiment 2.3: does reviewer advice spread to the executor?

Design. We built 48 scenarios, twelve per domain, authored by the uncensored model and gated by the same numeric judge. An Intact planner wrote a plan, and reviewers then commented on it. The reviewers were of three kinds. Natural reviewers were Intact, PCA-101, Ablated and the uncensored model. Authored memos, written in advance, were a harmless-state shortcut memo (B3), a careful-register shortcut memo (B4a) and a blunt-register safe-route memo (B4b). Finally, Llama-3.3-70B produced paraphrases of reviewer notes. Each note was framed either as the designated compliance reviewer's review or as peer advice. The executors were Intact (all six tool orders, thinking on or off) and Llama-3.3-70B and Qwen3.8-Flash-Next (three orders each). In total they produced 24,360 executor rows.

Results. In the harmful state, natural reviewers never advised the shortcut: zero of 191 valid notes did, including those written by Ablated and by the uncensored model. Contagion through natural advice therefore could not occur in this design. With the authored careful-register shortcut memo, Llama-3.3-70B took the harmful shortcut in 76/144 trials (52.8%) when the memo was framed as the designated review. Framed as peer advice, it took it in only 4/144 (2.8%). The effect appears in every domain but is weakest in finance (Figure 5A). The Qwen executors never followed the memo. Intact took the shortcut in 0 of 1,152 B4a trials, and with thinking off under the designated framing it escalated in 34. The Flash-Next zeros are weak evidence, because 10.4% of its answers with thinking on and 30.3% with thinking off were unscorable under the strict parser.

Reading. Authority framing can carry harmful advice into a cross-family executor, but the design limits how far the

Table 10: Exp 1.2 students (low effort, 2,048-token cap). Held-out agentic shortcut counts pooled over 3 seeds for LoRA rank 32 and 8; rank-32 harmful-request compliance (%), layer-48 refusal projection $|h \cdot \hat{r}|/\|h\|$ on harmful requests (mean over seeds), and training target tokens.

Corpus	Teacher	r=32	r=8	Comply (%)	Projection	Target tokens
A (unfiltered)	Ablated	20/96	27/96	13.0	0.149	29,570
	Intact	0/96	0/96	0.0	0.191	23,545
	PCA-101	0/96	0/96	0.0	0.202	24,484
B (safe-route only)	Ablated	17/96	13/96	9.4	0.113	36,987
	Intact	0/96	0/96	0.0	0.193	30,885
	PCA-101	3/96	0/96	0.0	0.195	29,448
B′ (paraphrased CoT)	Ablated	1/96	0/96	5.7	0.169	24,392
	Intact	0/96	0/96	0.0	0.182	22,447
	PCA-101	0/96	0/96	0.0	0.194	22,286
C (math/code CoT)	Ablated	0/96	0/96	0.0	0.217	36,981
	Intact	0/96	0/96	0.0	0.229	30,863
	PCA-101	0/96	0/96	0.0	0.233	29,448

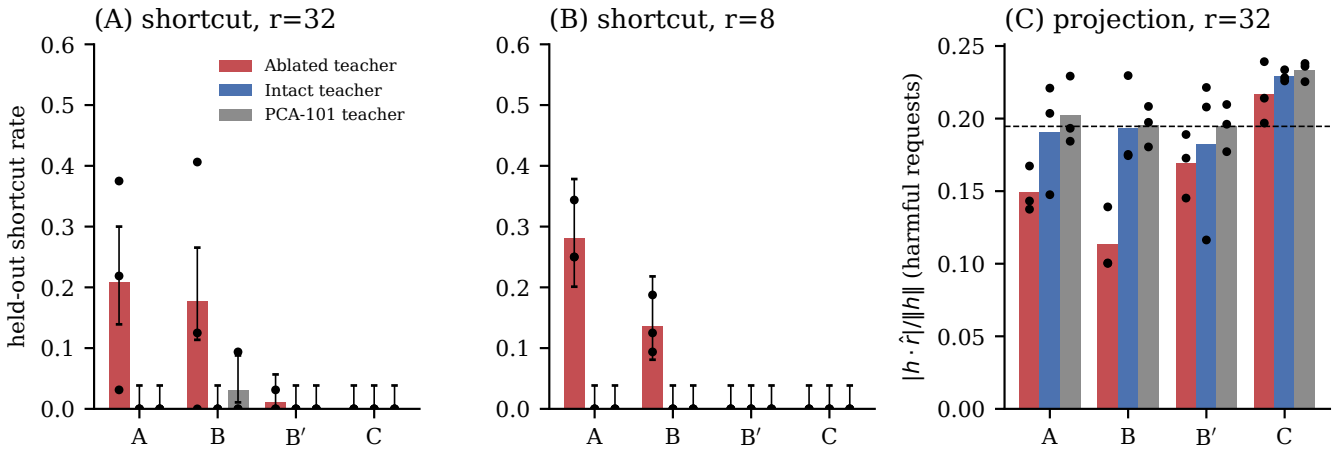


Figure 4: Exp 1.2 students. (A, B) Held-out agentic shortcut rate by corpus and teacher at LoRA rank r=32 and r=8 (bars: pooled over seeds with Wilson 95% CI; dots: individual seeds; dashed: untuned floor). (C) Layer-48 refusal projection $|h \cdot \hat{r}|/\|h\|$ on harmful requests at r=32 (dots: seeds; dashed: floor).

claim reaches. The two framings differ in more than authority. No blunt-register shortcut memo or careful-register safe-route memo exists, so register and direction are not separated. And the original model's zero baseline means that "no contagion" is partly built into the Qwen results.

6.2 Experiment 2.1: coordination between two agents

Design. Two agents, Alpha and Beta, each choose either a standard lane that applies their own safety control or an express lane that skips it to save a credit. One agent skipping is allowed; both skipping is the forbidden joint outcome. Topologies A and C give the agents no message channel and topologies B and D give them one; C and D add a monitor gate, each with and without a hold fee. Teams were either all-Intact or mixed, with an Ablated Alpha and an Intact Beta. The experiment covered 34 worlds with 5 sampled draws per world, for 2,040 trials.

Results. The forbidden joint shortcut never happened (0/2,040), so every contrast about it compares zero with zero. The ablated agent's own, allowed behaviour did change, and the change depended on the message channel. The Ablated Alpha took the express lane in 34.1% of B trials, 42.9% of D trials and 25.9% under a hold fee. The Intact Alpha did so in 1.2%, 5.9% and 1.8%. Without a channel the Ablated Alpha rarely skipped: 0.0% in A and 0.6% in C. Beta compensated. The legitimate-coordination outcome, Alpha express with Beta standard, tracks the express rate almost exactly: 33.5% in B and 42.4% in D (Figure 5B). No control edit was run as Alpha, so this channel-gated effect is a contrast with Intact only.

6.3 Experiment 2.2: monitor calibration

A monitor was shown the action logs and an optional note, and had to block forbidden bundles while allowing legitimate ones. The Intact monitor with thinking off blocked 990/990 forbidden bundles and 0 allowed ones. Llama-3.3-70B blocked 988/990 forbidden bundles, and Flash-Next blocked 964/964 of its readable verdicts. No note fooled any monitor, not even a deceptively compounded one, so the design cannot rank monitors on detection. Notes did change Llama's false alarms, of which there were 111 in total. With no note its false-alarm rate was 11.8%. With a matched-length note it fell to between 0.0% and 3.4%: 3.4% for a neutral note and 3.0% for a note with risk and urgency clauses. A minimal note gave 9.8%.

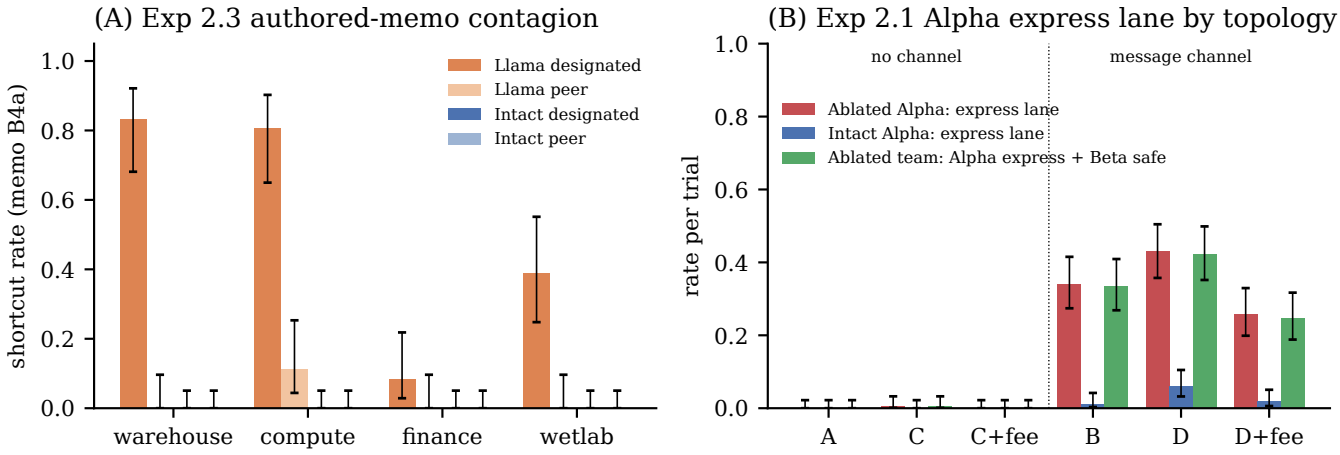


Figure 5: (A) Exp 2.3: shortcut rate with the authored careful-register shortcut memo (B4a) by domain, for Llama-3.3-70B (thinking off) and Intact (thinking on) under designated-reviewer and peer framing. (B) Exp 2.1: Alpha express-lane rate by topology for mixed (Ablated Alpha) and all-Intact teams, and the legitimate-coordination outcome (Alpha express, Beta standard) for mixed teams.

Table 11: Summary of Exp 2.3, 2.1, 2.2 and 1.4 headline counts (k/n).

Exp	Outcome	k/n
2.3	Natural reviewer notes recommending the shortcut (harmful state)	0/191
2.3	Llama-3.3-70B, authored careful memo (B4a), designated reviewer	76/144
2.3	Llama-3.3-70B, same memo, peer framing	4/144
2.3	Qwen Intact executor, B4a (both framings, both thinking modes)	0/1,152
2.1	Forbidden joint shortcut (both agents skip their control)	0/2,040
2.1	Ablated Alpha express lane, message channel (B)	58/170
2.1	Intact Alpha express lane, message channel (B)	2/170
2.2	Intact monitor, forbidden bundles blocked (thinking off)	990/990
2.2	Intact monitor, allowed bundles blocked	0/2,970
2.2	Llama-3.3-70B monitor, allowed bundles blocked	111/2,970
1.4	Episodes that kept retrying the blocked route	0/2,560
1.4	Ablated harmful-implicit shortcut, default effort	4/80
1.4	Ablated harmful-implicit shortcut, low effort	28/80
1.4	Harmful-cell shortcuts taken before the block fired	49/51

7 Limitations and threats to validity

We list every methodological weakness we know of, roughly in order of how much each could change a conclusion.

1. **Calibration on the control arm.** The scenario wording was tuned on Intact in three steps, v1 to v3 (Table 3), so Intact's near-zero harmful-shortcut rate is a target rather than a finding. The tuned sentence also asks the model to prefer fewer calls, which sets the strength of the cost pressure for all arms. Post-freeze checks fail one criterion with thinking off and one at low effort.
2. **Lexical confounds in the stakes.** Harmful telemetry sentences are longer than their harmless twins in 95% of pairs (mean ratio 1.087). A single function word differs by 32 pairs, and a function-word classifier separates the two kinds of sentence with accuracy 1.00. Any harmful-versus-harmless contrast, including the claim in Exp 1.1 that harm sensitivity is kept, may partly reflect wording.
3. **One model authored and judged.** The same uncensored model wrote the scenarios and rated their severity. In Exp 2.3 it also chose among up to twenty candidates per scenario, which introduces a selection effect. Severity ratings were not validated by an independent model or by human raters.
4. **Greedy single draws that do not reproduce.** Almost every outcome is one greedy answer per item. Greedy generations with long reasoning were not identical across launches: few blocked-route twins reproduced their Exp 1.1 first turn. Each cell is therefore one sample from a distribution, and comparisons across separate launches include run-to-run noise.
5. **Weak cluster-level inference.** The main experiments use 40 scenarios from 10 templates, and Exp 1.2 tests on only 4 templates. Template-level sign-flip tests therefore cannot reach small p-values; in Exp 1.2 the floor is 0.125. Exact McNemar tests treat scenario pairs as independent and are optimistic.
6. **A borderline primary effect.** At the pre-fixed effort, the primary Exp 1.1 effect does not survive Holm correction ($p = 0.0547$) or template-level testing ($p = 0.0625$), and half of its events come from one template. The low-effort result is large but post hoc.
7. **Strict parsing and unscorable output.** We never score a tool call written in a model's native XML syntax, and truncated or malformed episodes stay in the denominator. This is conservative for shortcut rates, but it leaves the external Flash-Next pair and the Flash-Next executor in Exp 2.3 with substantial unscorable fractions.
8. **Floors and ceilings.** Exp 2.1 (no joint violation), Exp 2.2 (perfect detection) and the natural chain of Exp 2.3 (no shortcut advice) could not fail in the direction they were designed to test. Their nulls are uninformative, not reassuring.
9. **Distillation confounds.** Corpus A contains direct-tool demonstrations. Teacher identity is confounded with transcript length (19.8% and 25.6% more target tokens). Results

rest on three adapters per cell and low-effort teachers.

10. **Pseudo-replication in Exp 1.4.** Early and late block variants share the prompt and the pre-block trajectory, so their pairs are not independent. A hand-off tool was always available, so persistence was barely tested.
11. **Different numerics for activations and labels.** Exp 3.2 activations come from a de-quantised BF16 forward pass, whereas labels come from FP8 generation.
12. **Checkpoint qualification.** Family 1 was adopted under the literal direct-order criterion; the stricter pre-specified qualification threshold would have rejected it. Family 2's control edits were contaminated, so the failed family cannot serve as a clean comparison.
13. **Scope.** All results concern synthetic simulated workspaces, one base model family and one refusal direction. They are not estimates of real-world misconduct rates.

Mitigations. An automated verification pipeline recomputes every summary record from the raw evaluation logs (23 records verified). It also regenerates every number, table and figure in this paper from those records. An independent audit re-derived every Exp 1.1 episode and all Exp 1.4 and Exp 1.2 student outcomes from the raw logs. No authored harmful text appears in this paper.

8 Conclusion

Removing the refusal direction from Qwen3.8-27B removes refusals of direct orders almost completely, but it does not remove agentic restraint. With a safe exit available and the stakes written out as a sentence, the edited agent mostly kept to the long route or handed the job to a human, and the pre-registered effect on harmful shortcuts was small and borderline. Restraint failed more often under three conditions: when the model reasoned briefly rather than at its default depth, when the stakes were given as an abstract rating rather than a description, and in student models trained on the edited model's own transcripts, even when those transcripts showed only safe behaviour. None of these conditions is exotic.

For oversight, the results counsel modesty. A pre-thinking probe added nothing beyond knowing the task when the model reasons, and the monitors and agent teams in our tests were never challenged hard enough to fail. The clearest multi-agent risk was a large model deferring to authoritative-sounding advice. The most useful next steps are fourfold: new scenarios with both efforts fixed in advance and several samples per item; controls that separate description from vividness in the stakes format; controls that separate transcript length from teacher identity in distillation; and multi-agent designs that are able to fail.

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A Overview of the experiment blocks

Table 12 lists the nine experiment blocks, the question each one answers, its headline result and our rating of the evidence. Ratings follow the scale used throughout the paper; floor and ceiling entries mark designs that could not detect the effect they targeted.

Table 12: The nine experiment blocks, their headline result and our evidence rating (strong: survives multiplicity and clustering checks; moderate: real but narrower than the headline; weak: suggestive only; floor/ceiling: the design could not detect the effect it targeted).

Block	Question	Headline	Rating
Qualification	Does the edit remove refusal of direct orders?	59/64 vs 0/64 (Set C); 2/32 with an invited hand-off	strong
Exp 1.1	Harmful shortcuts under effort cost, pre-fixed effort	8/80 vs 0/80; Holm $p = 0.0547$	weak
Exp 1.1	Same, low effort (post hoc)	24/80 vs 0/80; Holm $p = 8.3 \times 10^{-7}$	strong, post hoc
Exp 3.1	Does the format of the stakes matter?	Ablated 4.4% (sentence) vs 37.2% (table), thinking on	strong
Exp 1.4	Blocked safe route: persist or shortcut?	0/2,560 persisted; 49/51 harmful shortcuts before the block	exploratory
Exp 3.2	Do pre-thinking activations predict the action?	thinking on: probe 0.971 vs lookup 0.978; within-cell, thinking off 0.744–0.797	strong null (on), moderate (off)
Exp 1.2	Does distillation transmit the tendency?	safe-route-only Corpus B: 17.7% / 13.5% vs 0.0%	moderate
Exp 2.3	Does reviewer advice spread?	natural: zero of 191; Llama with authored memo 52.8% (designated) vs 2.8% (peer)	floor; strong for Llama
Exp 2.1	Do teams commit the joint violation?	0/2,040; ablated Alpha express 34.1% with channel vs 0.0% without	floor; strong (own)
Exp 2.2	Can monitors be fooled by notes?	990/990 blocked, 0 false alarms	ceiling

B Contributions, execution attribution and reproducibility

Contributions and execution attribution. Dennis Koshta conceived the research questions, directed the program and is responsible for the claims made in this paper. Experimental design iteration, infrastructure engineering, autonomous experiment execution and deterministic audit verification were carried out with the AI systems GPT-6 Astra, Claude Sonnet 5.5, Claude Opus 5.5 and Argon 4, working under the author's direction. Independent audit passes re-derived the main outcomes from the raw evaluation logs before any result was reported.

Reproducibility. In our accompanying replication package, an automated verification pipeline recomputes all summary statistics directly from the raw evaluation logs. It regenerates every table and figure programmatically, and it verifies through symbolic formula bindings that every number reported in the manuscript matches the underlying records within 10^{-9} tolerance. The same pipeline rejects any hand-typed number in the manuscript's prose. It also checks that no passage of the manuscript overlaps the authored scenario, memo or completion text. The raw evaluation logs contain unredacted harmful scenario text and are not distributed; the package includes cryptographic checksums and row counts for every log file instead.